

Advertisement

TRANSPORTATION



Uber Freight CEO Lior Ron leaves to join self- driving startup Waabi as COO



Self-driving truck maker [Waabi](#) has hired autonomous vehicle industry veteran and Uber Freight CEO Lior Ron to step in as chief operating officer, as the startup looks to scale its commercial operations ahead of its planned launch of driverless trucks on public highways this year.

Rebecca Timoci, who previously spent six years building Tesla's charging network before the automaker gutted its charging staff last year, will take over as head of Uber Freight. Ron will stay on as Uber Freight's chief operating officer.

"[Ron] will lead the go-to-market strategy, expanding key partnerships, and really bringing Waabi from the phase that we've been in to commercialization at scale," Raquel Urtasun, Waabi's founder and CEO, told TechCrunch. "He has shown his ability to scale from inception to a \$5 billion revenue company with Uber Freight."

Urtasun and Ron go way back: Ron previously co-founded self-driving truck company Otto, which [Uber acquired in 2016](#). He overlapped with Urtasun at Uber, where the latter was chief scientist, leading the ride-hail firm's self-driving research from 2017 to 2021.

Uber Freight is a digital marketplace connecting shippers with carriers, and the company aims to integrate self-driving trucks with the platform via partnerships with startups like [Aurora Innovation](#)

TECH DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach
- How your solar rooftop became a national security issue
- A comprehensive list of 2025 tech layoffs
- Co-founder of Elon Musk's xAI departs the company
- Google CEO adds a new calendar feature at Stripe co-founder's request

and [Waabi](#). Uber’s partnership with Waabi isn’t affected by Ron’s departure, he said.

While working at Uber Freight, Ron says, he met regularly with chief supply chain officers and big carriers that he said “could not wait” for self-driving trucks.

“If the most impactful thing to do in the next decade is autonomy, and if the timing is right, then for me it’s really about joining forces with who I think is most positioned to lead the transformation,” he added.

- [NASA has sparked a race to develop the data pipeline to Mars](#)

- [Why I finally left Spotify](#)

TC

Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

Urtasun claims Waabi’s “AI-first” approach to scaling autonomy has allowed it to do more with fewer resources and in less time than competitors. Given this is a capital-intensive industry that’s seen several promising startups, like TuSimple and Embark, crash and burn, efficiency can be a major advantage.

Since it was founded in 2021, Waabi has raised \$287.7 million in total, the bulk of which came from a [\\$200 million Series B in 2024](#). Urtasun claims the company doesn't need to raise more to get to its next phase of growth.

The startup's chief competitor is Aurora, which this year [launched the first commercial driverless trucking route](#) in the U.S., and has raised nearly \$3.46 billion through a combination of venture capital and its public listing.

Waabi has managed to launch commercial pilots quickly because it does most training, testing, and validation in Waabi World, its closed-loop simulator that both virtually tests the self-driving software and teaches it in real time. More recently, Waabi took its simulator to the test track, overlaying virtual environments onto real-world driving conditions to simulate scenarios like accidents and construction zones without the actual risk, according to Urtasun.

"At the beginning of the year, we reached feature complete, which basically means we have all the necessary things to remove the driver and [are focused] on the final performance improvement and validation," Urtasun said. "We are on track for our driverless launch by the end of the year, which is the start of commercialization."

The startup plans to launch in Texas, which has become the autonomous freight capital of the U.S., but it hasn't yet disclosed which routes it'll operate on or with which launch partners. The startup is [working with Volvo Autonomous Solutions](#) to develop and deploy custom-built AVs.

"Waabi will lead the technology and it will scale autonomy faster than ever expected," Ron said, adding that he's excited with the prospect of integrating the technology into the customers' operations. Part of that is a feature that would

enable Waabi's trucks to drive straight to customer depots, avoiding the need to build terminals for a hybrid setup.

"We're going to create a commercial-ready solution that can really meet them," Ron said.

We're always looking to evolve, and by providing some insight into your perspective and feedback into TechCrunch and our coverage and events, you can help us! Fill out [this survey](#) to let us know how we're doing and get the chance to win a prize in return!

Topics: [AI](#) [autonomous vehicles](#) [lior ron](#)

[Raquel Urtasun](#) [self-driving trucks](#) [Startups](#)

[Transportation](#) [uber freight](#) [Waabi](#)



Rebecca Bellan

Senior Reporter |

Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————



Latest

Security

Startups

AI

Venture

Apps

[Events](#)[Podcasts](#)[Newsletters](#)

IMAGE CREDITS: AALO ATOMICS

Nuclear startups have been soaking up attention from hyperscalers and cash from investors. Aalo Atomics is the latest beneficiary of the big tech-small nuclear love affair, raising \$100 million in a Series B, the company announced today.

The startup plans to flip the switch on its first reactor in the summer of 2026, CEO Matt Loszak [said](#) in a LinkedIn post. The facility will be located on the campus of the Idaho National Laboratory.

Aalo — not to be confused with the [defunct furniture startup](#) — could be considered a pseudo-spinout of the Department of Energy lab, which developed and open-sourced a small modular reactor design called Marvel. The company's CTO, Yasir Arafat, previously led Marvel's design, which Aalo says "inspired" its prototype. Aalo also received [development support](#) from the Idaho National Lab as part of an Obama administration program to accelerate nuclear reactor development.

Tim De Chant — 8:41 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

Newsletters

[See More ↗](#)

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

The Series B round was led by Valor Equity Partners with participation from 50Y, Alumni Ventures, Crescent Enterprises, Crosscut, Fine Structure Ventures, Gaingels, Harpoon Ventures, Hitachi Ventures, Kindred Ventures, MCJ, NRG Energy, Nucleation Capital, Perpetual VC, Tishman Speyer, and Vamos Ventures.

If Aalo can meet its aggressive deadline, it would buck a trend in the nuclear industry, which has a history of long timelines compounded by delays.

Like many advanced nuclear startups, Aalo is counting on economies of scale to help rein in both costs and build times. If the company can prove its approach works, it says it will build thousands of Aalo Pod power plants, which will consist of five Aalo-1 reactors delivering heat to a single turbine to generate a total of 50 megawatts of electricity.

The startup says that the Aalo-X prototype will also have an “experimental” data center built next door, a detail that sounds more like a marketing ploy than a technological innovation.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

Ultimately, Aalo says it aims to deliver electricity at three cents per kilowatt-hour, a price that would [make it competitive](#) with new natural gas power plants and solar farms built today. The startup hasn't put a timeline on that price, though, a wise move given the nuclear industry's [previous promises](#).

Aalo isn't the only nuclear startup making news this week. Yesterday, Kairos said that the Tennessee Valley Authority agreed to buy 50 megawatts of generating capacity from its Hermes 2 power plant, which the startup is planning to build in Oak Ridge, Tennessee. Google, in turn, will use that power to drive its data centers.

Topics: [Climate](#) [data centers](#) [Enterprise](#)

[nuclear fission](#) [nuclear power](#)

[valor equity partners](#)



Tim De Chant

Senior Reporter, Climate | [X](#) [🦋](#) [in](#)

Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including...

[View Bio](#) >

———— KEEP READING ————

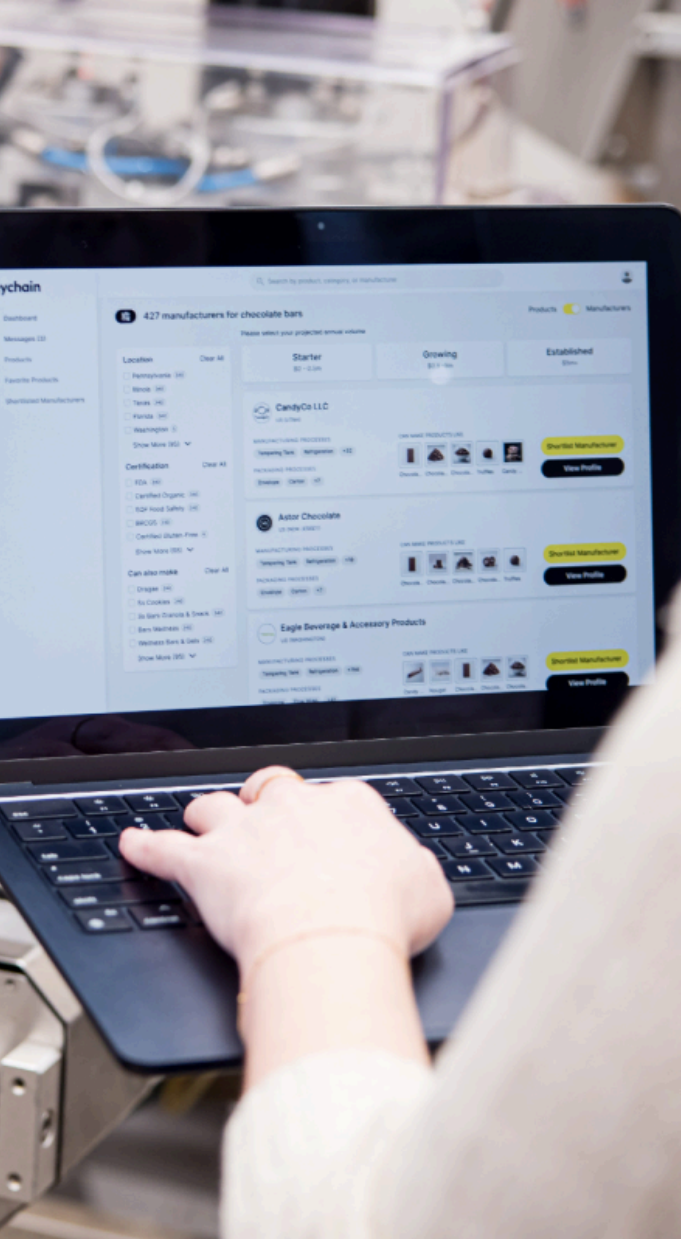


IMAGE CREDITS: KEYCHAIN

ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh — 7:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

[Keychain](#), a U.S. startup that [helps consumer brands find manufacturing partners](#), has raised \$30 million in fresh funding as it looks to scale its India-based development team to drive growth in North America.

While headquartered in New York, Keychain operates as a distributed company with its core engineering and product development centered in India. The startup is doubling down on this model with the new funding, aiming to grow its engineering, product design, and analytics teams in Gurugram from 35 to 70 in the coming months, and to around 100 within a year. This India-based team

Latest in Enterprise

[See More](#)

CLIMATE



Aalo Atomics raises \$100M to build a microreactor and data center together

Tim De Chant - 6 minutes ago

already represents half of Keychain’s 70-person global headcount, with about 20 employees in New York and the remainder in Austin, handling partnerships, go-to-market, and sales.

The strategy is deliberate. Despite only serving Western markets, Keychain has built its primary development operations in Gurugram — which is the country’s second-largest tech hub after Bengaluru — to develop its consumer packaged goods (CPG) platform for clients in North America. The software platform already helps eight of the top 10 retailers, including 7-Eleven and Whole Foods, and seven of the top CPG brands, such as General Mills, connect with potentially suitable manufacturers, according to the startup. So why India?

“It’s the talent, depth, availability, and the speed with which you can access talent of that depth and availability [in India],” said Oisin Hanrahan, co-founder and CEO of Keychain, in an interview.

Hanrahan co-founded Keychain in 2023 with Umang Dua — his co-founder at Handy, a home services software startup later acquired by Angi — and Jordan Weitz. Dua, who is originally from New Delhi, has been a “natural advantage” in building Keychain’s core teams in Gurugram, Hanrahan said.



ENTERPRISE



CPG startup Keychain snags \$30M to build in India, grow in the U.S.

Jagmeet Singh - 2 hours ago

ENTERPRISE



SoftBank makes \$2B investment in Intel

Kirsten Korosec - 15 hours ago

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Both Hanrahan and Dua spent time structuring Keychain's teams across India and the U.S., ultimately choosing India as the company's engineering hub. The decision was shaped by their experience at Handy and Angi, where they found it challenging to build a "sustainable, enduring" engineering team in the U.S.

"We've thought about engineering as: how do we build a core, sustainable engineering organization that can get to scale reasonably quickly, that has endurance, that's got deep talent pools, and AI exposure that can take on real, important challenges, that's commercially minded? And we looked at where we had those teams before, when we were at Handy and Angi, and obviously, India is just an amazing location and really checks a lot of those boxes," Hanrahan told TechCrunch.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

Several U.S. startups, [especially those developing SaaS solutions](#), base their engineering and product teams in cities like Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Noida. In recent months, the country has also seen a [wave of multinational companies establishing offshore hubs](#), often referred to as global capability centers. But unlike most of these firms — which also target Indian consumers even as many say [India is harder to sell into](#) — Keychain stands apart. It more closely resembles companies like the UK's [Deliveroo](#) and Southeast Asia's [Gojek](#) and [Grab](#) — all of which tap into India's tech talent for product development and R&D without having a market presence in the country.

“India's position as a global technology hub has made it a compelling destination for product development, even for startups that have no direct business in the country,” said Neha Singh, co-founder of the Bengaluru-based private market intelligence platform Tracxn, in an interview with TechCrunch.

India's time zone also allows teams to work beyond U.S. hours, enabling near-continuous development cycles, Singh added.

KeychainOS as the next big thing coming from Indian talent

Keychain plans to use its India team not only to improve its current platform — launched in February 2024 and used by over 20,000 brands and retailers to find manufacturing partners — but also to build new AI-powered software that helps manufacturers manage their product cycles more efficiently and with better oversight.

Called KeychainOS, the software will have four modules, with the first one already available. This module helps manufacturers comply with their food safety requirements, using AI to take quantitative data and convert it into a qualitative report that can be shared with auditors. The software can also pull data using natural language when an auditor requests a specific insight, Hanrahan told TechCrunch.

The other three modules of the software will focus on purchasing and procurement, inventory, and production planning, the executive noted.

The OS offering will compete with traditional ERP systems like Oracle, QAD, and Plex, which require add-ons like TraceGains and Redzone to be usable for manufacturers, the startup said.

In addition to its KeychainOS for manufacturers, Keychain has embedded AI into its search and discovery layer to help retailers quickly find relevant third-party manufacturers for their products.



KEYCHAIN'S SEARCH AND DISCOVERY LAYER WITH AN AI
INTEGRATION

IMAGE CREDITS:KEYCHAIN

Keychain already helps brands and retailers find third-party manufacturers in food, beverage, supplements, health, and beauty categories and is looking to expand its platform to pet and household products later this year.

Currently, the startup serves businesses in the U.S. and Canada and is [aiming to enter Europe](#) later this year.

While the startup offers its software free to brands and retailers, manufacturers pay to access the platform and get discovered. KeychainOS provides them with another reason to engage.

Keychain already has over 30,000 manufacturers on its platform, with “hundreds and hundreds” paying to use it. These customers pay anywhere from \$10,000 to over \$100,000, Hanrahan said, adding that the startup earns around \$20,000 per manufacturer annually on average.

Keychain’s Series B round was led by Wellington Management and existing investor BoxGroup, alongside other existing investors. With this funding, the startup has raised \$68 million in total. Of that, Hanrahan told TechCrunch that the startup still has over \$50 million in the bank.

The startup had a post-money valuation of \$260 million in its last round of \$15 million in November 2024. Hanrahan did not disclose the current valuation but said it was a “good step up.”

Topics: [Enterprise](#) [India](#) [Keychain](#) [KeychainOS](#)

[North America](#) [Startups](#) [United States](#)

Advertisement

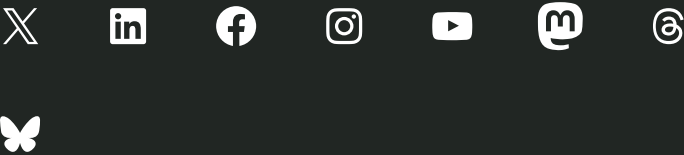
Jagmeet Singh

Reporter | [X](#)[🐼](#)[m](#)[in](#)

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

View Bio >

Loading the next article



TechCrunch
Staff
Contact Us
Advertise
Crunchboard
Jobs
Site Map

Terms of
Service
Privacy
Policy
RSS Terms of
Use

Neuralink
Google Chrome
StubHub
Claude
GPT-5
Tech Layoffs
ChatGPT